SWIM

Swim Drill Glossary

Print once and keep it in your pool bag. Every drill used across the year is here.

Notation used in the swim sheets

Term	Meaning
FS	Freestyle
WU / CD	Warm-up / Cool-down
4 x 50 r20	Four repeats of 50 m, resting 20 seconds after each
25 drill / 25 swim	First length is the drill, second length is normal freestyle applying the feeling
TT	Time trial: maximal, evenly paced effort. Record the time
CSS	Critical Swim Speed: roughly your 1500 m race pace, from a 400 m and 200 m test
Easy / Steady / Strong	Easy = conversational. Steady = Zone 2, could hold for 30+ min. Strong = Zone 3-4, breathing hard

All drills

Drill	How to do it and what it trains
Kick with board	Board held at arm's length, face in the water, exhale, breathe forward or to the side. Kick comes from the hips with a soft knee, toes pointed, ankles loose. Small and fast beats big and slow. Purpose: leg endurance and ankle flexibility.
Kick on side	One arm extended in front, palm down, other arm on your hip. Ear rests on the extended arm, body rolled about 45 degrees, hips at the surface. Kick steadily; rotate the head to breathe without lifting it. Switch sides every 25. Purpose: balance and body line.
6-3-6	Six kicks on one side (as in Kick on side), three full strokes, six kicks on the other side. Keep the hips high and the extended arm still while kicking. Purpose: rotation, balance, and timing the arm switch with the hips.
Catch-up	Both arms start extended. One arm pulls and recovers while the other waits out front; the recovering hand touches the waiting hand before the next stroke starts. Purpose: long stroke, front-quadrant timing, patience in the glide.
Fingertip drag	Swim normally but during the recovery let the fingertips trail along the surface, elbow high and pointing to the ceiling. Purpose: relaxed, high-elbow recovery and shoulder rotation.
Fist drill	Swim freestyle with closed fists. You will feel the forearm doing the work. After 25 m of fists open the hands and notice the extra grip. Purpose: early vertical forearm and feel for the water.
Sculling (front)	Arms extended in front, elbows slightly bent, hands sweep in and out in small figure-8s with the palms angled like a windshield wiper. Head down, gentle kick or pull buoy. Move forward slowly. Purpose: feel for the water and catch pressure.
Single-arm	One arm swims, the other stays extended in front. Breathe to the side of the working arm. Focus on the catch: fingertips down, elbow high, press back not down. Switch arms every 25. Purpose: catch mechanics and rotation.
Zipper	During recovery, drag the thumb up the side of the body from hip to armpit before reaching forward. Purpose: high elbow recovery and body rotation.
3-3-3 breathing	25 m breathing to the left every stroke, 25 m to the right, 25 m bilateral (every 3rd stroke), then repeat. Exhale continuously through nose and mouth while the face is in the water. Purpose: symmetrical stroke and calm breathing for open water.

Drill	How to do it and what it trains
Build 50	Start the 50 easy and finish it fast, without letting the stroke shorten. Purpose: learning to raise speed by pressing harder on the water, not by spinning the arms.
Stroke count	Count strokes per 25 m (one arm = one stroke). Write down your normal count, then try to hold pace with one fewer. Purpose: efficiency and distance per stroke.
Descend	Each repeat in the set is slightly faster than the previous one. The first should feel too easy.
Pull (buoy)	Pull buoy between the thighs, no kick. Focus entirely on the arm stroke and on keeping the body long. Paddles are not used in Month 1.
Sighting	Every 6-8 strokes lift the eyes just above the surface (crocodile eyes) at the start of a breath, then turn the head to breathe. Practised from Month 4 for open water.

Pool etiquette and safety notes

Pick a lane matching your pace. Rest at the wall corners, not the middle. If a set feels wrong (shoulder pain, dizziness) stop the set and swim easy. Hydrate: a bottle at the end of the lane, sip every 400-500 m.